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Holy Fire

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CHAPTER 1

The Need for Holy Fire

DISCERNING THE TIMES The Spirit clearly says that in later times some will abandon the faith and follow deceiving spirits and things taught by demons. . . . For the time will come when men will not put up with sound doctrine. Instead, to suit their own desires, they will gather around them a great number of teachers to say what their itching ears want to hear. They will turn their ears away from the truth and turn aside to myths.

But you, keep your head in all situations. —1 TIMOTHY 4:1; 2 TIMOTHY 4:3–5, NIV The worst thing that can happen to a man is to succeed before he is ready. —D. MARTYN LLOYD-JONES I WRITE THIS BOOK FOR THE YOUNG CHRISTIAN, THE NEW CHRISTIAN, the theological student, the new pastor, but also the seasoned layman or minister who aspires more than ever to be jealous for the honor and glory of God.

I write also for the fence straddler out there who is sincerely baffled and unsure of what to believe about the Holy Spirit. Jonathan Edwards said that the one thing Satan cannot produce in us is a love for the glory of God. So if the reading of this book results in a greater love for the honor of God and deeper reverence for the Holy Spirit, you may be sure that the devil did not put that desire and respect there.

This is also why Edwards stated that when the church is revived, so is the devil! So you may count on the devil putting every obstacle in your way to rob you of the joy that comes from intimacy with the Holy Spirit. Indeed, Satan will do everything he possibly can to lure you away from tasting the genuine power of the living God. I want to anticipate certain cautions you may face down the road.

Whether your background is conservative evangelical, Reformed, charismatic, or Pentecostal, there are certain pitfalls you need to be aware of. In each of these streams you need to be armed to withstand the pressures that come from a revengeful Satan who does not want you to grow in grace and knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. “My people are destroyed from lack of knowledge” (Hos. 4:6). In this connection I would mention (1) lack of knowledge of God’s Word and (2) lack of knowledge of God’s ways.

The first thing is the reading of the Bible. The devil does not want you to read your Bible, much less spend a lot of time reading the Bible. How well do you know your Bible? To understand the Bible you must be on good terms with the Holy Spirit. He wrote the Bible (2 Tim. 3:15; 2 Pet. 1:21). He alone can open your mind to understand His own Word.

When we grieve the Holy Spirit through bitterness or quench Him through fear, the inevitable result is an inability to focus on His Word. And yet to put it the other way around, to be on good terms with the Holy Spirit you need to know your Bible—and know it well. I fear there are ministers around who never seriously read the

Bible through but only consult the Bible when it comes to preparing a sermon.

You need a Bible reading plan. For years I have recommended the plan designed by Robert Murray M'Cheyne (1813–1843), which Dr. Martyn Lloyd-Jones introduced to me the first week I was the minister of Westminster Chapel in 1977.¹ It takes you through the whole Bible in a year including the New Testament twice and Psalms twice. This keeps you in God's Word. I heartily recommend it. You will never be sorry you started this and stayed with it.

Be a Christian who knows his or her Bible. This is so pleasing to God. Second, the way you know someone's ways is by spending time with them. You show your esteem of a person by how much time you give them. So I will come right to the point: How much do you pray? The devil does not want you to pray, much less spend a lot of time praying.

And Satan trembles, when he sees The weakest saint upon his knees.² —WILLIAM COWPER (1731–1800) I urge at least thirty minutes a day in your quiet time—including Bible reading and prayer. For the person in full-time Christian ministry, I suggest a minimum of an hour a day (two is better), and this should be for private devotions and quiet time without using any of this time for sermon preparation. Martin Luther spent two hours a day in prayer.

John Wesley spent two hours a day in prayer. According to a recent poll taken on both sides of the Atlantic, the average church leader (pastor, priest, evangelist, teacher) today spends four minutes

a day in prayer.³ And you wonder why the church is powerless? Where are the Luthers today? Where are the Wesleys? Who is truly turning the world upside down? As for time in prayer, if you don't know how to use up that time, get a prayer list.

Pray for people who will never know you prayed for them. Pray for your friends. Pray for your enemies. There will be no praying in heaven. I would lovingly plead with you: spend much time in prayer now. Get to know God and His ways by spending time with Him. THE GOD OF THE BIBLE VEDT RUS ANGEROUS TEACHINGS I cannot predict exactly what obstacles you will face, but I will mention briefly some that are at large.

For example, if you are in a charismatic or Pentecostal church, there are some strange teachings you will likely be confronted with. They come down basically to one thing: your view of God. The God of the Bible is sovereign, omnipotent, omnipresent, omniscient, and holy. In my books *The God of the Bible* (CrossBooks) and *Totally Forgiving God* (Charisma House) I share these attributes of God in more detail. 1.

The sovereignty of God refers to His divine right to do what He pleases. “I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy” (Exod. 33:19; Rom. 9:15). He “works out everything in conformity with the purpose of his will” (Eph. 1:11). 2. The God of the Bible is omnipotent—all powerful. There is nothing He cannot do (Luke 1:37). 3. The God of the Bible is omnipresent. He is everywhere; there is no place He is not present.

Always be looking for His manifest presence. Peter called this, “times of refreshing” (Acts 3:19). 4. He is omniscient—He knows everything, past, present and future. Yes, He knows the future as perfectly as He knows the past, declaring the end from the beginning (Isa. 46:10). 5. The God of the Bible is a holy God. He demands holiness of us in our personal and private lives (1 Pet. 1:16). Never forget that you and I will stand before the judgment seat of Christ one day to receive what is “due” us for the things done “while in the body, whether good or bad” (2 Cor.

5:10). A defective view of the God of the Bible has resulted in dangerous teachings in recent years in certain charismatic or Pentecostal circles. By Pentecostal I mainly mean a denomination—such as Assemblies of God, Pentecostal Holiness, Foursquare Gospel, Church of God, and Elim. By charismatic I refer to a movement that grew up spontaneously in the 1960s, stressing the gifts of the Holy Spirit (especially speaking in tongues) and crossed denominational lines—for example, Episcopal, Reformed, Baptist, Lutheran, and Presbyterian.

I’m afraid there are a lot of strange teachings out there that have crept into these churches or movements. One is called hyper-grace teaching. I will mention this heresy yet again in chapter 5—“Strange Fire.” The view comes to this: since Jesus dealt with all our sin on the cross, there is no need to confess sin—it has already been dealt with. No need for repentance in the Christian life, say these people.

This is tantamount to antinomianism (anti-law) and can so easily lead to ungodly living. The people who uphold this kind of thinking have actually had to eliminate certain books of the Bible, for example, Hebrews and 1 John. Imagine that! To uphold a teaching they have to cut out part of the canon of Holy Scripture! I warn you, this teaching grieves the Holy Spirit. It is a fad. It will not last.

But it can do incalculable damage in the meantime. The second teaching I mention here and again in chapter 5 is called open theism. This view of God brings Him down to the level of man so that such a God does not know His own mind without our input. The idea is that we actually help God know what to do next; without us He cannot move forward. This is sub-Christian teaching.

It has astonishingly crept into certain charismatic circles. When one leader of this teaching was asked publicly in London, “With this view of God, is it not possible that God could lose out in the end?” The reply was: Yes. Imagine a God like that. The God of the Bible wins! Such a weak view of God is the ultimate consequence of denying His eternal sovereignty. On the heels of open theism is the notion that we can virtually make God do anything.

We can decree something, and it will come to pass. This makes man sovereign. It is sometimes a part of the health and wealth and prosperity teachings. While it is absolutely true that God promises to bless the tither (Mal. 3:10)—for we cannot outgive the Lord (2 Cor. 9:8), beware of those who pitch this point of view mainly to advance their personal ministries. Some leaders go so far as to claim that their

words of knowledge are superior to Holy Scripture.

Some deny the Bible as being the complete and final revelation of eternal truth. One leader said, “If the apostle Paul had my faith, he would not have had a thorn in the flesh.” I’m sorry, but this kind of doctrine has emerged in charismatic and Pentecostal settings. Be wise to teaching that exalts any man or woman and even appeals to a person’s greed. They emerge from strange fire, teachings that are alien to Holy Scripture.

However, do not let your view of the infallibility of Holy Scripture keep you from believing that God speaks to us directly today. He does. Do not believe for one moment that the God of the Bible does not perform miracles today. He does. And don’t abandon your view that the Bible is God’s final and complete revelation of eternal truth. It is. My prayer is that you will uphold Holy Scripture as God’s infallible Word while simultaneously believing that God is unchanging in His willingness to manifest His power (Mal.

3:6; Heb. 13:8). It would therefore be a great pity—and a victory for Satan—if you let strange teachings disillusion you. I write this book to encourage you to wait for and expect the conscious and manifest presence of the third person of the Godhead—the Holy Spirit. T W HEOLOGY AND ORSHIP Having had one foot in the Reformed camp and the other in the charismaticPentecostal camp, I have been increasingly alarmed at the trend in some of the worship among the latter camp.

The early Methodists got their theology mostly from their hymns. This made them theologically minded—a trait you and I must never lose. Whose hymns did the early Methodists sing? They sang those written by such people as Isaac Watts (1674–1748), Charles Wesley (1707–1788), William Cowper, and John Newton (1725– 1807). Read them. Sing them. Have you had a look lately at the words of hymns such as, “And can it be that I should gain an int’rest in my Savior’s blood?,”⁴ “When I survey the wondrous cross on which the Prince of glory died,”⁵ “God moves in a mysterious way His wonders to perform,”⁶ “How sweet the name of Jesus sounds,”⁷ or “O for a heart to praise my God, a heart from sin set free”⁸?

I would plead for the present generation of all Christians to sing the new as well as the old. Jesus spoke a parable about “the owner of a house who brings out of his storeroom new treasures as well as old” (Matt. 13:52), a truth that could readily apply to new and old hymns. What worries me most about some contemporary worship is its lack of good theology. Some seem to have almost no theology at all!

This is not good. I fear that we are producing a generation of people who are vulnerable to heretical movements partly because of a lack of good grounding in the truth. That said, I thank God for hymns such as Chris Bowater’s “Jesus Shall Take the Highest Honour”; Graham Kendrick’s “Restore, O Lord,” “Knowing You, Jesus,” and “Such Love”; Stuart Townend’s “How Deep the Father’s Love For Us” and “In Christ Alone”; Matt Redman’s “Blessed Be Your Name” and “10,000 Reasons”; Stephen Fry’s “Oh the Glory of

His Presence”; Darlene Zschech’s “Shout to the Lord”; and others.

But there are pitfalls in conservative Evangelicalism too. One teaching that is common in Reformed theology is called cessationism. The idea is that the miraculous ceased sometime after the last apostle died or when the canon of Scripture was complete. This concept is so important I will devote both chapters 8 and 9 to it. Cessationism is not a fad. It has been around for a long time. Those who uphold this are not heretics.

They are good people. But cessationism quenches the Holy Spirit as much as the previously mentioned teachings that displease Him. You will not likely convince a cessationist to believe that the living God heals supernaturally today. A man convinced against his will is of the same opinion still! I just don’t want some of these people to convince you! So do not let those who hold to their views that God will not manifest His power today deter you from seeing the God of glory show Himself in our generation.

That is why I write this book. As I said, my own theological stable is Reformed. But I came into it not by reading Reformed theology. My purpose in writing this book, however, is not to change your theology but to make you hungry for the Holy Spirit. If you walk in the Spirit, know your Bible, and spend sufficient time alone with God, your theology will take care of itself.

My greatest mentor was Dr. Martyn Lloyd-Jones. Through this book I want to make him better known and a blessing to you as much as he was to me. The greatest thing he ever said to me was

this: “The worst thing that can happen to a man is to succeed before he is ready.” This statement is what helped me keep my head when God did not manifest His power in my own ministry as quickly as I hoped.

But I never gave up. I don’t want you to give up! Chapter Two WHAT EVERY CHRISTIAN SHOULD KNOW ABOUT THE HOLY SPIRIT I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth . . . he dwells with you and will be in you. —JOHN 14:16–17, ESV If the Holy Spirit was withdrawn from the church today, 95 percent of what we do would go on and no one would know the difference.

—A. W. TOZER (1897–1963) THE DISCIPLES OF JESUS DID NOT ENJOY HEARING ABOUT THE Holy Spirit. It made them uneasy, as we will see below. Today some Christians feel much the same way. The mention of Him makes them uneasy. There can be many reasons for this. In the case of conservative evangelicals, they sometimes think that charismatics talk more about the Holy Spirit than they do about Jesus or the gospel.

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CHAPTER 2

Who Is the Holy Spirit?

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In my own experience I have often observed that there are a surprising number of charismatics who have little or no assurance of why they are saved. The proof of this is when I preach the gospel in some of their churches. I often ask these questions, borrowing from the late D. James Kennedy's *Evangelism Explosion*¹ (the best soul-winning program I have come across): 1. Do you know for sure that if you were to die today you would go to heaven?

2. If you were to stand before God (and you will) and He were to ask you (and He might), “Why should I let you into My heaven?,” what would you say? I have been shocked how many of them (all over the world) admit that their hope of heaven is not in the blood of Jesus but their own efforts. This is worrisome. It makes me feel many of them have not heard the gospel at all!

And yet this lack of assurance would also be true in some conservative evangelical churches when they are taught that it is not looking to Christ alone but to your good works as being the only way you can be sure you have been converted, as we will see further in chapter 3. There are also conservative evangelicals who feel at times that they are being judged as being unspiritual by overly zealous people—especially if they do not speak in tongues.

Rightly or wrongly, some are made to feel they are not even Christians or are—at best—second class. However, any reference to the Holy Spirit in some situations can be almost counterproductive. The reason the Twelve did not like the idea of the Holy Spirit—at least at first—was because it sent a signal to them about Jesus’s departure. To the Twelve, the Holy Spirit meant losing Jesus. The initial reference to the Holy Spirit came simultaneously with the mention of Jesus’s going away.

This was upsetting. After all, the Twelve felt they were at long last getting to understand Jesus Himself. They were slowly getting to know some of His ways. They had followed Him for three years. They knew what He looked like. They knew His height, the color of

His eyes, hair, and skin. They knew the sound of His voice. They heard His sermons, the parables, the dialogues with Pharisees and Sadducees.

They saw the miracles, the healings. They saw Him walk on water. They were convinced He was the long-awaited Messiah who would come. They anticipated Him setting up His kingdom and overthrowing Rome at any moment. But Jesus began to talk about going away. The notion of Him going away was puzzling. I wonder if they listened very carefully at all. The reason I say that is because even after He was raised from the dead—and was around for forty days—the only thing on their minds was: When would Jesus restore the kingdom (Acts 1:6)?

Had they truly taken in what Jesus taught, they would not have asked that question. In any case, Jesus did all He could to spoon-feed them and break to them gently as possible that He was going away. Jesus’s task was to help them to make the transition from the level of nature to the realm of the Spirit. It would not be easy. Any thought of a transition was nowhere in their thinking.

THEY SAW THAT THE HOLY SPIRIT WOULD TAKE HIS PLACE. Jesus introduced the Holy Spirit to them by carefully telling them it was in their interest that He depart. “It is for your good that I am going away” (John 16:7). He talked about “another” Comforter or Counselor coming along (John 14:16). But the very idea of “another” person did not interest them in the slightest.

The Greek word is *parakletos*—a word impossible to translate into one word so that it is fully meaningful—whether it be comforter, advocate, helper, or counselor. The word literally means, “one who comes alongside”—which Jesus in fact was to the Twelve at the natural level. He had indeed come alongside them during those three years. They were very happy with Jesus, Jesus in the flesh. The thought of Him leaving them was confusing, upsetting, and very painful.

So the notion of “another” Paraclete did not bless them at the time. The whole concept of the Holy Spirit was threatening to them. Do you feel threatened by the Holy Spirit? The disciples of Jesus were threatened by the thought of the Spirit because they liked things just as they were—except for waiting for Jesus to overthrow Rome. They were at ease with the idea of Him setting up His kingdom.

The word kingdom to them had a good sound. By the end of three years with Jesus these disciples were firmly in their comfort zones. After all, they were quite convinced they would be right in on the new regime. James and John even hoped to sit at Jesus’s right hand and left hand in this kingdom. In any case, they looked forward to His kingdom. But they could only think at a natural level, even though Jesus clearly said that His kingdom was not something you can see with your naked eye (Luke 17:20–21).

So if you feel threatened by the Holy Spirit, is it because you are happily in your comfort zone? Are you afraid of what the Holy Spirit

might do to you? What He would require of you? What He might ask you to do? Do you think you will lose something if you make yourself vulnerable and totally open to Him? Are you afraid He will embarrass you? Do you think you will lose your identity?

Do you think you might have to change? Whether the disciples listened carefully to Jesus, we only know that He kept on speaking. One of the things Jesus said was that the Holy Spirit would remind them of what He had taught them. It was indeed the Holy Spirit who enabled them to go back to those sermons and discourses—remembering them all by the help of the Spirit. And not only the words but also the very meaning.

T -O T WENTY NE HINGS There are twenty-one things every Christian should know about the Holy Spirit. These twenty-one principles, built upon what I have said up to now, summarize the things the Bible says about the Holy Spirit generally and what Jesus said about the Holy Spirit particularly. 1. The Holy Spirit is God. When Ananias lied to the Spirit, he lied to God (Acts 5:4). “The Lord is the Spirit” (2 Cor.

3:17). We may speak of the deity of Jesus Christ—that He is God—because He is. And yet we don’t feel a need to speak of the deity of the Father—it would be redundant. Sometimes I think I would like to preach on the Godhood of God! The most neglected member of the Trinity these days is God the Father. That said, I would like to talk about the deity of the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit is God—every bit as much as Jesus being God or the Father being God. Some Christians don’t mind singing the first two verses of this chorus: Father, we love You We worship and adore You Glorify Thy name in all the earth . . . Jesus, we love You We worship and adore You Glorify Thy name in all the earth . . . But when it comes to the third verse it is a different matter: Spirit, we love You We worship and adore You Glorify Thy name in all the earth .

. . 2 Some Christians feel uncomfortable singing that verse. Why? Because the Authorized Version translated John 16:13—referring to the Holy Spirit —“He shall not speak of himself,” a verse that should be translated, “He will not speak on his own,” as I show further below. I actually sympathize with them. I know where they are coming from. I used to have the same problem until I saw what the Greek literally said.

And yet traditional church hymnals for many years have included hymns with lyrics such as “Holy Spirit, Truth divine, dawn upon this soul of mine,”³ “Holy Ghost, dispel our sadness,”⁴ “Lord God, the Holy Ghost, in this accepted hour, as on the day of Pentecost, descend in all Thy power,”⁵ or “Spirit of God, descend upon my heart.”⁶ You could not address the Holy Spirit like that if He were not God.

Do not be afraid to talk directly to the Holy Spirit. There is no jealousy or rivalry in the Trinity. The Father is happy and the Son is happy when you address the Holy Spirit in prayer. After all, the

Spirit of God is God the Spirit. What is more, the Trinity is not God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Bible! Just remember: the Holy Spirit is God.

2. The Holy Spirit is a person. Jesus referred to the Holy Spirit as “he” (John 14:16; 16:8) and introduced Him as being “another” paracletos (which is what Jesus was). Never think of the Holy Spirit as an “it,” an “attitude,” or an “influence.” He is a person and has very definite ways. Call them peculiar, eccentric, or unique if you like; He has His ways. You may or may not like His ways.

But get over it! He is the only Holy Spirit you have! He won’t adjust to you; you must adjust to Him. The Holy Spirit Himself spoke of ancient Israel as not knowing God’s “ways” (Heb. 3:7–10). God was grieved because His own covenant people did not know His ways. They should have. But they didn’t. God has His own “ways” and wants us to know them. And so too it is when it comes to the person of the Holy Spirit.

He wants us to know His ways. As we will see below, the Spirit can be grieved, He can be quenched, and He can be blasphemed. The Holy Spirit can also have joy. In Romans 14:17 Paul talked about “joy in the Holy Spirit” (emphasis added), whereas Paul referred to the “joy of the Holy Spirit” in 1 Thessalonians 1:6 (ESV, emphasis added). It is His own joy. This joy is not necessarily what we feel; it is what He feels.

And yet sometimes He invites us to feel what He feels! It is called “gladness” in Acts 2:28 (ESV). That is exactly what I experienced

years ago driving in my car, an event to which I will return later. We need therefore to learn the difference between feeling happy because of circumstances and feeling the very “joy of the LORD” (Neh. 8:10). There is certainly nothing wrong with our feeling happy because things are working out for us.

Indeed, there was “joy in that city” when many who had been paralyzed were healed (Acts 8:7–8). Good news about Gentiles being converted made the disciples “very glad” (Acts 15:3). But the highest level of joy on this planet is when we are allowed to experience the very joy of the Spirit—feeling what He feels. For when the Spirit lets us feel His joy, it is truly “inexpressible” (1 Pet.

1:8). 3. The Holy Spirit is eternal. “How much more, then, will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself unblemished to God, cleanse our consciences from acts that lead to death, so that we may serve the living God!” (Heb. 9:14, emphasis added). The Father, the Son, and the Word existed in eternity before God chose to create the heavens and the earth (Gen. 1:1). “Before the mountains were born or you brought forth the whole world, from everlasting to everlasting you are God” (Ps.

90:2). God the Father is eternal, and so is the Holy Spirit. When Paul said that in the fullness of time God “sent his Son” (Gal. 4:4), it is because the Father already had a Son. Jesus Christ is the eternal Son. He was the Word until the moment He became “flesh” (John 1:14). That did not happen in Bethlehem but at His conception in Nazareth the moment the Word entered the womb of the Virgin

Mary.

The Holy Spirit is equally eternal with the Father and the Word. This is the same Holy Spirit whom Jesus talked about and introduced to His disciples. It is also easy to find mention of the Holy Spirit in the Old Testament. He was, in fact, present all the time. Pharaoh discerned the Spirit of God was in Joseph (Gen. 41:38). Bezalel was filled “with the Spirit of God” (Exod.

31:3). The “Spirit of the LORD” was upon Othniel (Judg. 3:9–10), Gideon (Judg. 6:34), Jephthah (Judg. 11:29), Saul (1 Sam. 10:10), and David (1 Sam. 16:13). The Holy Spirit lay behind the ministry of Elijah (1 Kings 18:12; 2 Kings 2:16). The Spirit of God came upon Azariah (2 Chron. 15:1) and Zechariah (2 Chron. 24:20). The references to the Holy Spirit go on and on. One of the greatest of all is this: “‘Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit,’ says the LORD of hosts” (Zech.

4:6, NKJV). As we will see again below, Jesus said that the Holy Spirit spoke through David in Psalm 110:1 (Matt. 22:43). It was the testimony of the early church that God spoke “through the mouth of . . . David, your servant, said by the Holy Spirit” (Acts 4:25, ESV). Indeed, as we will see below, the Holy Spirit had a role in Creation and was the author of all Scripture.

4. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of truth (John 14:17; 16:13). Jesus said of Himself that He is the “way and the truth and the life” (John 14:6, emphasis added), and so equally the Holy Spirit is truth. As it is impossible for God to lie (Heb. 6:18), never forget that the Holy

Spirit is incapable of lying to you. He will never deceive you. Jesus Himself was full of grace and “truth” (John 1:14).

Truth means fact. It means what is reliable. What Jesus does can be proved and will not let you be ashamed. When a miracle was performed, the enemy of truth was forced to say, “We cannot deny it” (Acts 4:16). Jesus is transparent integrity. Today we sometimes use the expression “the real deal.” It is what people want to see in leaders, what people long for in relationships—no deceit, no infidelity, but honesty and trustworthiness.

That is what we want in a friend —pure gold, the real thing. Jesus is that. The God of the Bible is that—His words are “trustworthy” (2 Sam. 7:28), “true, and righteous altogether” (Ps. 19:9, ESV). And so virtually the first thing Jesus said about the Holy Spirit was that He is “the Spirit of truth” (John 14:17). This means genuineness, trustworthiness, faithfulness, and integrity. It also means theological truth.

The Holy Spirit will never lead you to error. What He reveals you can believe and stake your life on. To put it another way, the Holy Spirit is the opposite of the devil. Jesus said of Satan: “There is no truth in him . . . for he is a liar and the father of lies” (John 8:44, ESV). He is incapable of telling the truth. He lives to deceive.

Do you know the feeling of being deceived? To know what it is to embrace a person, recommend them, put your ministry on the line for them —then find out you were deceived! It can be very painful. The Holy Spirit, however, will never mislead you. You don’t need to

be afraid of Him. He may not be “safe,” but He is “good.” 5. The Holy Spirit was involved in Creation.

“The Spirit of God was hovering over the waters” (Gen. 1:2). We know that Jesus is depicted as Creator. “Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made” (John 1:3). “For by him all things were created: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities; all things have been created by him and for him.

He is before all things, and in him all things hold together” (Col. 1:16–17). Some of these lines could describe the Holy Spirit—for example, that He is before all things. The Holy Spirit had a hand in Creation, as Jesus did. 6. The Holy Spirit, using people, wrote the Bible. “All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness” (2 Tim. 3:16). “For prophecy never had its origin in the human will of man, but prophets, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit” (2 Pet.

1:21). Jesus had the same view of Scripture that Paul and Peter held to, namely, that the Holy Spirit wrote the Old Testament. Jesus asked the Pharisees (a question they could not answer), “How is it then that David, speaking by the Spirit, calls him [Christ] ‘Lord’? For he says, ‘The Lord said to my Lord: “Sit at my right hand until I put your enemies under your feet.”’ If then David calls him ‘Lord,’ how can he be his son?”

(Matt. 22:43–45, emphasis added). My point is, Jesus said that David was able to write as he did because the Holy Spirit—in 1,000 BC—enabled him to do so. And, as we also saw earlier, it was the testimony of the early church. When being persecuted, they turned to the Lord and said, “You spoke by the Holy Spirit through the mouth of your servant, our father David: ‘Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?’” (Acts 4:25, emphasis added).

One more thing in this connection. The canon of Holy Scripture is closed. It is final. Absolute. Incontrovertible. It is God’s complete and final revelation. No word that will come in the future will be equal to the Bible in level of inspiration. This means that any leading, prophetic word, word of knowledge, or vision one may have today must cohere with Holy Scripture. If it doesn’t, it must be rejected.

The main reason that King Saul became yesterday’s man and rejected by God was because he thought he was above the Word of God. When he offered the burnt offerings, he knew he was going right against Moses’s mandate that only the person called of God could offer burnt offerings. And yet he claimed to have been “compelled” to do it (1 Sam. 13:12). Whenever a person claims to speak for God, claiming “The Lord told me”—and it goes against Scripture, you may safely, comfortably, and most assuredly reject that person’s word, no matter how credible that person may seem!

The Holy Spirit takes the responsibility for the authorship of the Bible. He used people of course. But the buck stops with the Holy

Spirit. The same Holy Spirit may speak today at various levels. But no level of inspiration will equal the inspiration of the Bible—ever.

7. The Holy Spirit is our teacher. “He will teach you all things” (John 14:26, ESV). “You do not need anyone to teach you.

But as his anointing teaches you about all things and as that anointing is real, not counterfeit . . . remain in him” (1 John 2:27). The Holy Spirit is our teacher in basically two ways: directly and indirectly—a most important concept, which I will unpack in detail later. If He teaches us directly, then, “you do not need anyone to teach you.” The Holy Spirit is very capable of teaching us in that fashion, and it is a wonderful thing to have happen.

The things I was taught directly had been alien to me—for example, that I was eternally saved and chosen from the foundation of the world. I could not have thought that up in my own mind. I was taught the opposite—that such teaching was actually “born in hell” (I am not joking). So how did I come to it? By the direct teaching of the Holy Spirit. The indirect teaching refers to the way the Holy Spirit applies what we read or hear.

It is when the Spirit applies the Word of God when we read it. It is when the Spirit applies preaching, teaching, a blog, a poem, a loving word of encouragement from a friend, or when singing a hymn or chorus. As it happens, this very morning in my quiet time I sang the hymn, “Be Still, My Soul” to the tune “Finlandia.” Only God (and Louise, who was with me) knew what those words meant to me on this particular day.

It was as though they were penned for me! The Holy Spirit was at work applying this great hymn. The Holy Spirit is our best and only reliable teacher. In fact, He is the only teacher who matters. Whatever teaching you hear or read (including this book)—whoever the preacher or teacher, if the Spirit does not apply it and witness it to your heart (which He is most capable of doing), you should learn to hold that teaching in abeyance—if not dismiss it.

Caution: the Holy Spirit only witnesses to the truth. Remember too that the best of teachers make mistakes; they are not infallible. You must be like the people of Berea who “examined the Scriptures [the Old Testament in this case] every day to see if what Paul said was true” (Acts 17:11). In those days Paul was a nobody; he did not have the stature then he has today. Anyone who says to you, “Believe it because I say it,” is doing you no favor and is probably insecure in himself.

8. The Holy Spirit can be grieved. “Do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you were sealed for the day of redemption” (Eph. 4:30). You will recall that the Holy Spirit is a person. He can be grieved. The Greek word *lupeo* can mean, “get your feelings hurt.” What hurts the Holy Spirit’s feelings? Chiefly, bitterness. The next thing Paul says is: “Get rid of all bitterness, rage and anger, brawling and slander, along with every form of malice.

Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you” (Eph. 4:31–32). I have written an entire book on this subject, called *The Sensitivity of the Spirit*. Not

sensitivity to the Spirit, important though that is; the issue is how sensitive the person of the Holy Spirit Himself is. How easy it is to grieve Him, to hurt His feelings. When you think about this—anger, losing your temper, shouting when you get frustrated, speaking impatiently or unkindly of a person, holding a grudge, or pointing the finger—these things grieve the Holy Spirit!

But it doesn't seem to bother us! It should. If we are conscious of the sensitivity of the Holy Spirit, we will develop an acute sensitivity to Him—and be able (in ever-increasing measure) to hear His voice. This comes by living in love—keeping no record of wrongs (1 Cor. 13:5). In 1974 my family and I visited Corrie ten Boom (1892–1983) in Holland. I asked her, “Is it true that you are a charismatic?”

Without saying yes or no she bluntly replied: “First Corinthians 12 and 1 Corinthians 14. But don't forget 1 Corinthians 13.” It was a shrewd way of saying we need both the gifts and the fruit of the Holy Spirit. 9. The Holy Spirit can be quenched. “Do not quench the Spirit” (1 Thess. 5:19, ESV). “Do not put out the Spirit's fire.” What is the difference between grieving the Spirit and quenching the Spirit?

They almost certainly overlap. But if there is a difference, it is probably this: we grieve the Spirit by our relationships with one another—like judging and unforgiveness; we quench the Spirit when we are prejudiced toward the way the Spirit may be manifesting Himself and by not respecting His presence. It is usually fear that lies behind quenching the Holy Spirit. Whether we hold that the

Holy Spirit does not, will not, or cannot manifest today through the gifts of the Spirit or the miraculous, by adhering to cessationism, the Holy Spirit is put to one side before He is given an opportunity to show His power.

Don't be threatened by the Holy Spirit. Some would say that, "The Holy Spirit is a gentleman." I'm not sure I agree with that! Whereas I am sure you don't need to be threatened by Him, He may not be so "nice" as some might hope. Dr. Lloyd-Jones said often that the problem with the ministry today is that it has "too many nice men" in it. The Holy Spirit may require something of you that was not on your radar screen.

Back in 1982 I made the decision to give up my aspiration of being a great theologian—and instead be willing to take to the streets, give out tracts—not that I am suggesting they are mutually exclusive! I began to talk to complete strangers and passers-by about the Lord. It was so embarrassing! But I never looked back. So I do not say God will not require something of you that leads you out of your comfort zone.

You may indeed have to leave your comfort zone. But I can promise this: follow the Holy Spirit by being totally open to Him; you will be forever thankful. 10. The Holy Spirit will be the One who convicts. "He will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment" (John 16:8, ESV). Only the Holy Spirit can make us see our sin, show us the need for righteousness, and the urgency of the gospel—that there is judgment.

A person cannot feel convicted of these things on his or her own. It takes the Spirit to shake us rigid. This is true before and after our conversion. We cannot see our sin or the seriousness of unbelief before our conversion—we are all so self-righteous. It requires the Holy Spirit to make us see the painful truth—that we have grieved Him by self-righteousness and unbelief and are going to have to give an account of our lives at the judgment seat of Christ.

Even after conversion we must beware of self-righteousness. This is why John said—writing to Christians, “If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us” (1 John 1:8). It is also why it is good to pray the Lord’s Prayer daily—recalling the petition, “Forgive us our sins, for we also forgive everyone who sins against us” (Luke 11:4). The Spirit shows us our sin but also leads us to see the need for righteousness—of which there are two sorts: 1.

Righteousness imputed to us when we believe the gospel (called saving faith) 2. Righteousness imparted to us when we “continue to live in him” (called persistent faith—Col. 2:6) Righteousness is connected to Jesus’s ascension (“I am going to the Father, where you can see me no longer,” John 16:10) partly because the preaching of the gospel did not begin until Jesus died, rose from the grave, and ascended to the Father’s right hand.

But what is the “judgment” of which the Spirit promises to convict us? It is a reference to the final day—when the Judge of all the earth shall do right (Gen. 18:25). Satan is the cause of all the evil and injustice in this world. The death of Jesus took Satan by surprise

(1 Cor. 2:8) and not only spelled his downfall but also forecast the day of his judgment.

Death was defeated by Jesus's death (Heb. 2:14), which is why Jesus said, "The prince of this world now stands condemned" (John 16:11). People often ask, "Is there no justice in this world?" Answer: sometimes there is. But don't count on it. "Life's not fair," said John F. Kennedy. But one day God will openly bring about Satan's demise. God will explain the reason for evil and suffering. Everything will be put under Jesus's feet.

Satan himself will be "thrown into the lake of burning sulfur" (Rev. 20:10). The Holy Spirit convicts of this truth, testifying that Satan stands condemned but also that judgment is coming. For this reason, we "all" must stand before the judgment seat of Christ and give an account of the things done in the body, whether good or bad (2 Cor. 5:10). The Holy Spirit therefore convicts of the final judgment.

The affect this should have on us is godly fear. As soon as Paul mentioned standing before the judgment, he mentioned the "fear" of the Lord ("knowing therefore the terror of the Lord," 2 Cor. 5:11, KJV). The reference to judgment also points to the neglected teaching of eternal punishment. When Paul witnessed before Felix, he spoke of "judgment to come" (Acts 24:25). Felix was afraid. He trembled. In times of great revival there is often a revival of the teaching of judgment and eternal punishment.

And yet only the Holy Spirit can make this truth terrifying. If He does not come alongside when such is preached, people will be unaffected. 11. The Holy Spirit is our guide. “He will guide you into all the truth” (John 16:13). Unless you are led to see truth by the Spirit, you will never see it. “The man without the Spirit does not accept the things that come from the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him, and he cannot understand them, because they are spiritually discerned” (1 Cor.

2:14). Without the Spirit we will likely think it is our great brain that keeps us from seeing what is there. Only by the Holy Spirit guiding us can we understand the Bible and then experience the joy of the Spirit. My hobby for many years was bonefishing in the Florida Keys. A bonefish (called that because they are bony and virtually inedible) is a wily, skittish, hard-to-see, fast-as-lightning, shallow-water fish that is great fun to catch.

They average in size around six to eight pounds. But if you have never tried it, you are unwise to do so the first time without a professional guide. When I first heard this, I refused to hire a guide. First, I didn’t want to pay his fee. Second, I didn’t want to admit I needed a guide. But after repeated failures on my own I gave in—and hired a guide.

The funny thing was, he took me to the exact spots in Largo Sound where I had fished for months—without seeing any! With this kind of fishing—which requires stalking them and seeing them before they see you—it is imperative to see them before you cast to

them. But I hadn't even seen the first one! But with the guide I saw them in no time! I will never forget it.

I was eventually able to see them. And yet I would never have seen one on my own without a guide. The Spirit “guides” us into truth—showing what is there but what cannot be seen without Him opening our eyes. It is humbling for prideful people to admit to the need of the Holy Spirit. The cost? Our pride being shattered. But once we are broken and enabled to see our stubbornness, the Spirit will show us amazing things—in Scripture.

As it happens, I was recently in Bimini, Bahamas, to do some bonefishing. I hired a wonderful guide—“Bonefish Tommy.” Despite knowing how to see them (in the past), I realize how much I had forgotten on how to spot them, even in crystal-clear water only a foot or so deep. As a matter of fact, most of the fish I caught I had not seen at all; Tommy would usually tell me where to cast—and I would then catch them.

I felt so dumb! Sometimes we experienced Christians—who know sound theology— need to humble ourselves and admit our need for further illumination by the Spirit. I need the Holy Spirit more than ever. I have been reading the Bible for some seventy years. I have read it through about forty times. But sometimes I feel I've barely begun to know God and His Word. We never outgrow our need for the heavenly guide to lead us to truth we had never seen before—but which has always been there.

12. The Holy Spirit speaks only what the Father gives Him to say. “He will not speak on his own; he will speak only what he hears” (John 16:13). The Authorized Version (King James) is sadly famous for translating this verse “he shall not speak of himself,” which is one of the more unfortunate translations in biblical translation history. As we saw above, it has led good people to infer that they should barely (if at all) mention the Holy Spirit lest they say what the Spirit Himself would never allow.

This is a mistake. After all, the Holy Spirit wrote the New Testament! This is how we know about the Holy Spirit! The correct translation is not that He would not speak of Himself but that he will not speak “on his own” or “on his own authority” (ESV). This means He passes on what the Father tells Him to say. That is what the verse means. Never be afraid to talk about the Holy Spirit.

It is exactly what the Father and Son want you to do. The Holy Spirit, in fact, continued the same pattern Jesus followed. Jesus said, “I tell you the truth, the Son can do nothing by himself; he can do only what he sees his Father doing, because whatever the Father does the Son also does” (John 5:19). This means Jesus took His cue from the Father— what to say, where to go, when to heal, when to reply.

He did nothing without receiving the green light from the Father. Everything Jesus did had been orchestrated in heaven by the Father. Everything. The Son did nothing on His own. Ever. That is exactly what the Holy Spirit is saying about Himself. The Spirit does

nothing without the green light from the throne of grace—what to say, where to go, when to heal, when to reply. Concerning where to go, the disciples were once forbidden by the Holy Spirit to go into Asia—or Bithynia (Acts 16:7).

The Spirit was doing what the Father ordered; it was the will of the Father that they not go. God the Father orchestrated from heaven all that the Holy Spirit would say or do here on Planet Earth. That is the meaning of these words. Jesus never said that the Holy Spirit would not speak of Himself. In fact, He does speak of Himself. 13. The Holy Spirit will predict the future.

“He will tell you what is yet to come” (John 16:13, emphasis added). This is the basis for prophecy. We saw earlier some references to the Holy Spirit in the Old Testament. All prophecies in the Old Testament—from Moses to Elijah, from Samuel to Malachi—were borne by the Holy Spirit. I wrote a book based on Isaiah 53 called *Why Jesus Died*.⁷ Isaiah 53 is written in such a manner that one is amazed that Jews today could read that chapter and not see how Jesus and His death were perfectly predicted and fulfilled.

“I make known the end from the beginning, from ancient times, what is still to come. I say: My purpose will stand, and I will do all that I please” (Isa. 46:10). This is how Agabus knew a famine would be coming (Acts 11:28). This is how Paul knew the ship he was on would be shipwrecked (Acts 27:23–26). Never forget: God knows the end from the beginning. He knows the future as perfectly

as He knows the past.

14. The Holy Spirit will glorify Jesus Christ. “He will bring glory to me by taking from what is mine and making it known to you” (John 16:14). One of the interesting characteristics of the Trinity is that the persons of the Godhead heap praise on one another. As I said, there is no jealousy or rivalry in the Godhead. This is hard for some to grasp. The Father does not mind if you pray to Jesus or the Holy Spirit.

The Father honors the Spirit and the Son. The Son honors the Father and the Spirit. The Spirit glorifies Christ and speaks only what He hears from the Father. Glorifying Christ is honoring Him for: 1. Who He is 2. What He said 3. What He did for us 4. What He continues to do for us 5. What He will do It is giving Him the honor now that He will receive openly on the last day —when every knee shall bow and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord to the glory of God the Father (Phil.

2:9–11). You cannot praise Jesus too much. It is impossible to heap too much praise on the Lord Jesus Christ. The Holy Spirit leads us to praise the Lord Jesus as He deserves, although we all wish we could do better. This is why Charles Wesley wrote, “Oh, for a thousand tongues to sing my great Redeemer’s praise.”⁸ Jesus said that the Holy Spirit would take “what is mine.” What is His, and what is made known to us?

Answer: (1) His work as Redeemer, and (2) the glory and praise Jesus Christ deserves—what belongs to Him. Jesus is the focus. He

is the one who was to be glorified—and who was glorified. Jesus prayed, “Father, the time has come. Glorify your Son, that your Son may glorify you. . . . Glorify me in your presence with the glory I had with you before the world began” (John 17:1–5).

The glory of Christ is the focus. He is our Redeemer. He is the God-man. It is not the Spirit who is to be focused on when it comes to glory. You may ask: Is not the Holy Spirit God? Yes. But it was not the Holy Spirit who died. It is not the Holy Spirit to whom every knee shall bow one day. So when Jesus said that the Holy Spirit would take what is “mine,” He was stating that the focus would be on the Redeemer and Savior of the world who would be glorified and made known to us.

15. The Holy Spirit can be blasphemed. “Blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven” (Matt. 12:31). This is arguably the scariest passage in the New Testament. It is called the